

Anxiety Management Strategies

24-7 Hotline Numbers:

- Mobile Crisis 216-623-6888 <https://www.frontlineservice.org/wp-content/uploads/2018/02/Mobile-Crisis-Team-Brochure-2018.pdf>
- United Way First Call for Help at 211 <https://www.211oh.org/>
They also have online chat
- National Suicide Prevention Lifeline 1-800-273-8255
- Nord Center crisis services 1-800-888-6161

Not Quite 24-7

- Mobile Crisis online chat M-F 3-9 pm at [frontlineservice.org](https://www.frontlineservice.org) or can text 4HOPE to 741741
- WarmLine from the Nord Center (Lorain, OH) is M-F 1 pm to 10 pm 1-800-888-6161 and it is peer support <https://www.nordcenter.org/wp-content/uploads/2016/03/warmlineExpandedHours.jpg>

Grief Counseling

Cornerstone of Hope in Independence: (216) 524-4673

<https://cornerstoneofhope.org/>

4-7-8 Breathing: <https://www.medicalnewstoday.com/articles/324417.php>

How to do it

Before starting the breathing pattern, adopt a comfortable sitting position and place the tip of the tongue on the tissue right behind the top front teeth.

To use the 4-7-8 technique, focus on the following breathing pattern:

empty the lungs of air

breathe in quietly through the nose for 4 seconds

hold the breath for a count of 7 seconds

exhale forcefully through the mouth, pursing the lips and making a "whoosh" sound, for 8 seconds

repeat the cycle up to 4 times

(4-4-8 breathing is similar but you inhale for 4, hold for four and exhale over a count of 8)

5 Senses Exercise: <https://www.urmc.rochester.edu/behavioral-health-partners/bhp-blog/april-2018/5-4-3-2-1-coping-technique-for-anxiety.aspx>

5: Acknowledge **FIVE** things you see around you. It could be a pen, a spot on the ceiling, anything in your surroundings.

4: Acknowledge **FOUR** things you can touch around you. It could be your hair, a pillow, or the ground under your feet.

3: Acknowledge **THREE** things you hear. This could be any external sound. If you can hear your belly rumbling that counts! Focus on things you can hear outside of your body.

2: Acknowledge **TWO** things you can smell. Maybe you are in your office and smell pencil, or maybe you are in your bedroom and smell a pillow. If you need to take a brief walk to find a scent you could smell soap in your bathroom, or nature outside.

1: Acknowledge **ONE** thing you can taste. What does the inside of your mouth taste like—gum, coffee, or the sandwich from lunch?

1. Progressive Muscle Relaxation:

<https://www.anxietycanada.com/sites/default/files/MuscleRelaxation.pdf>

STEP ONE: Tension

The first step is applying muscle tension to a specific part of the body. This step is essentially the same regardless of which muscle group you are targeting. First, focus on the target muscle group, for example, your left hand. Next, take a slow, deep breath and squeeze the muscles as hard as you can for about 5 seconds. It is important to *really feel* the tension in the muscles, which may even cause a bit of discomfort or shaking. In this instance, you would be making a tight fist with your left hand.

It is easy to accidentally tense other surrounding muscles (for example, the shoulder or arm), so try to **ONLY** tense the muscles you are targeting. Isolating muscle groups gets easier with practice.

STEP TWO: Relaxing the Tense Muscles

This step involves quickly relaxing the tensed muscles. After about 5 seconds, let all the tightness flow out of the tensed muscles. Exhale as you do this step. You should feel the muscles become loose and limp, as the tension flows out. **It is important to very deliberately focus on and notice the difference between the tension and relaxation. This is the most important part of the whole exercise.**

Remain in this relaxed state for about 15 seconds, and then move on to the next muscle group. Repeat the tension-relaxation steps. After completing all of the muscle groups, take some time to enjoy the deep state of relaxation.

Or <https://www.uofmhealth.org/health-library/uz2225>

- Choose a place where you won't be interrupted and where you can lie down on your back and stretch out comfortably, such as a carpeted floor.
- Breathe in, and tense the first muscle group (hard but not to the point of pain or cramping) for 4 to 10 seconds.
- Breathe out, and suddenly and completely relax the muscle group (do not relax it gradually).
- Relax for 10 to 20 seconds before you work on the next muscle group. Notice the difference between how the muscles feel when they are tense and how they feel when they are relaxed.
- When you are finished with all of the muscle groups, count backward from 5 to 1 to bring your focus back to the present.

Sequence of Muscle Groups

- Right foot, then left foot
- Right calf, then left calf
- Right thigh, then left thigh
- Hips and buttocks
- Stomach
- Chest
- Back
- Right arm and hand, then left arm and hand
- Neck and shoulders
- Face

Mammalian Dive Reflex for panic attacks: CAUTION Do not do this if you have breathing problems.

<https://mentallyagile.com/blog/2018/12/29/the-mammalian-dive-reflex>

If you feel a panic attack coming on tapping into the mammalian dive reflex can be extremely effective. The mammalian dive reflex is built into our physiology. When mammals dive into cold water, the heartbeat slows, blood moves from the limbs to the chest and breathing slows down. We can trigger this response without actually diving

into water. Just fill a large bowl with ice and cold water and plunge your face into the ice bath for several seconds. Repeat a few times. Alternatively, place a cold ice pack over your eyes. It should be cold enough to shock your body and break the pattern of panic.

2. Visualization

There are all kinds of visualization resources. For a quick and easy one though, I tell my patients to pick a time in their lives where they felt the safest and then to try and remember that spot in as much detail as possible. For example, one of my patients said her grandmother's home was their safe place. I asked her to recall how the house smelled, what the sounds were, what was on the floors and walls, how her feet felt walking across the floor etc. etc.

Some other helpful websites:

<https://www.helpguide.org/articles/stress/relaxation-techniques-for-stress-relief.htm>

<https://drsarahallen.com/7-ways-to-calm/>

YouTube Videos:

Breathing: https://youtu.be/YRPh_GaiL8s

5 Senses Grounding Exercise: <https://youtu.be/5cEUenMhMoY> (many many different videos on this)

Progressive Muscle Relaxation: <https://youtu.be/intVpw4LhMY>

Podcasts:

Your Anxiety Toolkit

Owning It: The Anxiety Podcast

The Resilience Prescription

The Mindful Podcast